

Additional Composition Pair: Observational Studies and Governance Records

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This work derives from and formalizes the inter-Self coordination architecture introduced in “Inter-Self Coordination via Shared Substrate / Full Aspect Integration” (Li, April 2026), the third paper in the CKS theory series following “Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems” (Li, April 2026) and “The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model” (Li, April 2026).

Abstract

Two Paper 3 operational commitments — the Observational Study FAI Context (D2.68) and the Complete FAI Governance Record (D2.18) — can apply to the same event simultaneously. When they do, three governance requirements emerge that are not present when either commitment operates alone. First, records that serve both operational accountability and research evidence purposes must satisfy both sets of retention requirements; the longer of the two governs. Second, consent for research use of governance records must be explicitly linked within the records themselves, not merely asserted elsewhere; this linkage is the mechanism that distinguishes governed research from opportunistic use of governance data. Third, the research record that D2.68 requires constitutes an eighteenth governance record category, additional to and separate from D2.18’s standard seventeen. Each requirement is non-obvious: none can be read from either commitment in isolation. Together they define what a “governed AI governance research data collection” system must demonstrate in any architecture that combines observational study structure with complete governance record-keeping.

1. Pair Identification

Commitment A — Observational Study FAI Context (D2.68). A Full Aspect Integration (FAI) event may be structured as an observational study: participants provide consent for their governance activity to be observed and recorded for research purposes, and the event produces a research record as an additional governance artifact. The research record documents the research questions, design, methodology, preliminary findings, and references to participant consent. The consent itself is recorded in each participating Self’s home substrate as a governance authorization. D2.68 governs the conditions under which this structure is permissible and what it must produce.

Commitment B — Complete FAI Governance Record (D2.18). Every FAI event produces a governance record consisting of seventeen defined categories. These categories constitute the end-to-end accountability record for the event: they capture what happened, who participated, what was exchanged, how conflicts were handled, what evolution-feed content was produced, and what governance configurations were in effect. D2.18 specifies what “complete” means for an FAI governance record, and any deployment that claims complete governance accountability for FAI events must satisfy all seventeen categories.

The composition. When an FAI event is structured as an observational study, both commitments apply. The event is simultaneously a governed coordination operation (subject to D2.18’s complete record requirement) and a research activity (subject to D2.68’s research-context requirements). The governance records the event produces serve two purposes at once: they are operational accountability records and they are research evidence. Neither purpose is subordinate to the other.

2. Governance Scenario Requiring Both Simultaneously

Consider a FAI event between two coordinating Selves — one operating in a knowledge-infrastructure domain, one in a governance-research domain — that is formally structured as an observational study. Before the event, both Selves’ home governance authorities have authorized participation, and each participant has provided consent for the event’s governance records to be used as research data under a specified research protocol. The research questions concern how inter-Self conflict-handling operates in practice when the participating Selves have asymmetric aspect depth.

The event proceeds under normal FAI governance: shared substrate is constructed, aspects are contributed, conflicts surface and are handled, the evolution feed is produced, the event dissolves. All seventeen D2.18 governance record categories are generated.

Simultaneously, the event’s observational study framing means that D2.68 applies. A research record must be produced. The consent records in each Self’s home substrate are governance authorizations for the research use of the event’s governance data.

Both commitments are active. Neither can be satisfied by ignoring the other. The governance record the event produces must satisfy D2.18’s seventeen-category completeness requirement and the additional requirements that D2.68’s research-context framing imposes. This is the scenario in which the non-obvious requirements of the composition surface.

3. Non-Obvious Governance Requirements from the Combination

Requirement 1 — Dual Retention Policies for Dual-Purpose Records

Governance records ordinarily have a single retention requirement, set by the governance context in which the event operates. D2.36 Standard 4 specifies how operational accountability retention is determined: it is a function of the governance authority’s policies, the regulatory environment, and the

event's significance classification.

Research retention is a different matter. Research protocols, institutional review standards, and academic replication norms can impose retention requirements that are longer — sometimes substantially longer — than operational accountability periods. A governance record retained for three years under operational policy may need to be retained for ten years under a research protocol that requires data availability for independent replication.

When both commitments apply, both retention requirements must be satisfied. The more demanding requirement on each dimension governs. Specifically: if operational retention requires five years and research retention requires ten, the record must be retained for ten years; if research retention requires five years and operational retention requires eight, the record must be retained for eight years; neither purpose can shorten the retention obligation imposed by the other.

This is the dual retention policy requirement. It is non-obvious because no single-purpose governance record encounters it: operational records need only satisfy operational retention, and research records designed from the start as research data operate under research retention alone. The composition forces both onto the same record. Governance practitioners who specify retention policies for FAI governance records must, when D2.68 and D2.18 both apply, specify both policies and apply the longer of the two to every record that serves both purposes.

The practical governance implication is that retention policy specification for observational study events requires explicit enumeration of both the operational retention requirement and the research retention requirement for every record category, with documentation of which is more demanding and why. A retention policy that states only one of the two is incomplete for a dual-purpose record.

Requirement 2 — Consent Linkage Must Be Explicit in the Governance Records

Under D2.68, participant consent for research use of governance data is recorded in each participant's home substrate. The consent record is a governance authorization: it establishes that the participant, under the governance authority of their home substrate, has authorized their governance activity to be used as research evidence.

This authorization existing in the home substrate is necessary but not sufficient. For the governance records to be legitimately usable as research evidence, the records themselves must carry explicit linkage to the consent records that authorize their research use. Without that linkage, the governance records are indistinguishable — to an external auditor, to a research reviewer, or to a future practitioner examining the record — from governance records that were repurposed for research after the fact without consent. The presence of consent in a home substrate somewhere in the system does not prove that this record's research use was consented; only a traceable link from the record to the consent authorization proves that.

The consent linkage requirement is therefore: every governance record that is used for research purposes must contain, in an explicit and auditable field, a reference to the consent record in the

relevant participant’s home substrate that authorizes that use. This reference must be resolvable — it must point to a specific consent record, not merely assert that consent exists.

This requirement is non-obvious in two ways. First, it is not a requirement of D2.18 alone: the standard seventeen-category governance record has no consent linkage field, because standard FAI events do not involve research use of governance data. Second, it is not a requirement of D2.68 alone: D2.68 requires that consent be recorded in the home substrate, but does not by itself require that the consent reference travel into the governance record. The requirement emerges from the combination: the composition demands that the research-authorization chain be traceable from the governance record itself, not merely from the home substrate.

The governance mechanism this requirement establishes is what separates governed research from ungoverned use of governance data. A system that collects FAI governance records and uses them as research evidence without explicit consent linkage in the records is, architecturally, performing opportunistic data collection regardless of whether consent exists somewhere in the system. The linkage is not a formality; it is the evidence that the research use was authorized and the chain of authorization can be audited.

Requirement 3 — Research Record as Eighteenth Governance Record Category

D2.18 specifies seventeen governance record categories. These seventeen constitute the complete governance record for a standard FAI event. They are not a floor; they are the specification.

For observational study events, a research record is required by D2.68. This research record documents: the research questions that motivated the observational study structure; the research design, including which governance activities were observed and under what conditions; the methodology for extracting research findings from governance record data; preliminary findings or observations; and references to participant consent records. This is a distinct artifact with a distinct purpose.

The research record is not a modification or expansion of any of the seventeen standard categories. It is not a relabeling of the event description record or the configuration record. It has content that no standard category captures — research questions and methodology are not governance-record concepts — and it serves a purpose that the seventeen standard categories are not designed to serve. Treating it as an expansion of an existing category would misrepresent both the standard categories and the research record.

The research record is therefore an eighteenth governance record category, applicable specifically and only to FAI events that are structured as observational studies. Governance practitioners who produce governance records for observational study events must produce all seventeen standard categories (D2.18) plus the research record (D2.68), for a total of eighteen. The research record’s existence does not relieve the practitioner of any of the seventeen standard categories; it adds to them.

The distinction between “addition produced by the composition” and “modification of the standard” matters for governance practice. A practitioner who knows D2.18 but not D2.68 will produce seventeen

categories and believe the record is complete. A practitioner who knows both commitments but treats the research record as a variant of an existing category will produce a malformed record that conflates governance accountability with research methodology documentation. The correct framing — eighteen categories, where the eighteenth is produced by the composition and is additional to the seventeen — is what the combination requires.

4. Prior-Art Significance

The three requirements identified above — dual retention policies, consent linkage in governance records, and the research record as an eighteenth category — are specific architectural properties that emerge from the observational study plus complete governance record composition. They are not general principles about research governance or data retention; they are specific to this composition and would not be identified from either commitment independently.

Dual retention policies as a requirement for records that simultaneously serve operational accountability and research evidence purposes has not been articulated as an architectural property of inter-Self coordination governance. The general principle that records should be retained as long as any governing requirement demands is familiar in compliance contexts, but its application to FAI governance records — where operational and research retention requirements arise from structurally distinct commitments and may not even be managed by the same governance authority — is specific to this architecture.

Consent linkage in governance records as a mechanism that distinguishes governed research from opportunistic data use addresses a gap that arises specifically at the interface between operational governance and research use. Any system that collects governance records from AI coordination events and subsequently uses them for research must address this gap; the requirement that the linkage be explicit and auditable within the records themselves is the architectural solution the composition specifies.

The eighteenth record category as a composition product, distinct from and additional to the seventeen standard categories, formalizes the boundary between standard FAI governance and observational study FAI governance. Any system claiming to provide complete governance records for observational study FAI events that produces only seventeen categories is provably incomplete against the composition's requirements. This category boundary is prior art against any subsequent system that claims to support governed AI governance research data collection without identifying the research record as a distinct artifact.

Any “governed AI governance research data collection” system — any architecture that purports to use FAI governance records as research evidence in a governed, consented manner — must address all three requirements. The prior art established by this note covers the requirements individually and as a combination.

5. Operational Test

For a FAI event that was structured as an observational study, an observer examining the governance record produced by the event can verify governance completeness against the composition's requirements by checking three conditions:

(a) Dual retention policies are specified. The event's governance documentation must include an explicit retention policy statement that names both the operational retention requirement (per D2.36 Standard 4 or equivalent governance context specification) and the research retention requirement (per the applicable research protocol, institutional review standard, or academic norm). The documentation must identify which of the two is more demanding for each record category that serves both purposes, and must specify that the longer period applies. A retention policy that states only one of the two is incomplete.

(b) Governance records used for research carry explicit consent linkage. Each governance record that is designated for research use must contain a resolvable reference to the participant consent record in the relevant home substrate that authorizes that research use. The reference must be explicit — a specific identifier or locator — not merely an assertion that consent exists. An auditor reviewing the governance record must be able to follow the reference to the consent record without additional inquiry. Records that lack this linkage, or that carry only a general assertion of consent, do not satisfy the requirement.

(c) A research record exists as an eighteenth category. The event's complete governance record must include, in addition to the seventeen standard D2.18 categories, a research record that documents the research questions, design, methodology, preliminary findings, and consent references specific to the observational study. The research record must be a distinct artifact, not a section of an existing category record. Its presence alongside the seventeen standard categories — not as a replacement for any of them — is what verifiable completeness requires.

A governance record that satisfies all three conditions provides auditable evidence that the observational study event was governed under both commitments simultaneously, that research use of the governance data was consented and traceable, and that the record is complete against the composition's requirements. A record that fails any condition is incomplete regardless of how well it satisfies the requirements of either commitment in isolation.

Source Papers

Li, W. (2026). *Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

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